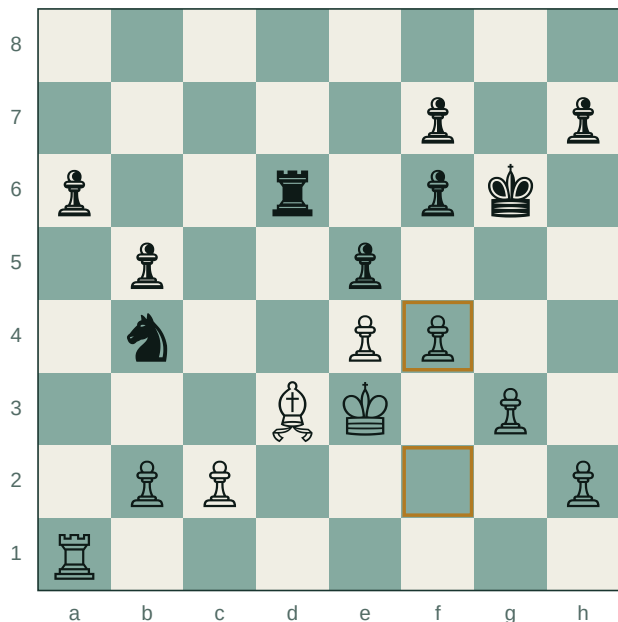


Calculated sacrifices: Black, move 24

Calculated sacrifices

Black to move



Previous move: 24.f4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

24...Rxd3+ 25. cxd3 Nc2+ 26. Kd2 Nxa1

24...Rxd3+ Check restricts White to 3 legal replies here. The move also takes the bishop on d3. Recorded reply: **25.cxd3**.

25...Nc2+ Check restricts White to 4 legal replies here. From c2 it attacks king on e3 and rook on a1. Recorded reply: **26.Kd2**.

26...Nxa1 The knight captures the rook on a1.

At the end, nominal material is White 6 / Black 9 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer: +3:** the balance goes from +0 to +3. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attractive attacking picture is not compensation by itself. Continue until the resulting position can be evaluated honestly.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A sacrifice exchanges material for a concrete benefit. The benefit may be mate, a stronger attack, a recovered investment, or lasting activity; it must be shown through moves.

HOW TO LOOK

State what the sacrifice changes: a defender, a line, a king square, or a critical tempo. Calculate acceptance and plausible refusal.

The defending king is on e3. Geometrically undefended: rook on a1. Check for tactical protection.